

None of that happens with an avatar. Even if the avatar is set to follow your actions and movements using your camera, it's still not going to drop its pants to sit down on a toilet when you do!

## WHAT ELSE?

So that's it? VR and Avatars make a metaverse? No, and we have five more stories on the topic to follow this one, because there is obviously a lot more to the metaverse than we can ever cover here.

What we're still struggling with is a nailed down definition for it. Meta (Facebook Inc) has a definition of their own. On Meta's own site (still <https://about.fb.com> as of writing), they describe the metaverse as, "...a set of virtual spaces where you can create and explore with other people who aren't in the same physical space as you."

But that's just about anything we do now, right? Here at Digit, the team is spread around the country and abroad as well, and we all collaboratively work on files together. It's not uncommon for us to be sitting on video calls, talking to one another just as we would if we were sitting in the office next to each other, working on multiple files at a time, quite often many of us are working on one file together. Is that the metaverse? Are teams using one of the myriad cloud services to work together remotely already participating in the metaverse experience? Maybe!

Because there's no definition that anyone can settle on, just about any real-time collaboration or communication, or socialising online could technically be qualified as part of the metaverse experience. In our team itself the opinions are varied. One group thinks the metaverse is just another buzzword that's trying to describe how tech advancement and the internet is changing, rather than the metaverse concept itself changing anything. Another camp thinks the metaverse concept is more than merely the internet, and is a huge push being engineered by Meta (previously Facebook Inc.), so that their large investment in Oculus comes good.

## THE UNIVERSE PROBLEM

There's one major problem with a universe. It's too big. It's too spread out. It's too isolated. Just look at the real universe we know exists, because we can see it on a cloudless night by looking up at the sky at any area of the planet not totally ruined by light pollution. And is that the universe we see? Not even close, that's just the Milky Way, or

to choose one of them to side with. Like picking a supermassive galaxy to start up in. Hundreds of such startups and services will fail before even a single one succeeds. The one that succeeds will be the shining star for that platform. Same thing will happen on a different platform, and all could be as isolated from one another just as we are from whatever life form was the closest to us in the vastness of space.



What virtual meet-ups in the Metaverse could look like

rather a small part of it that we see. In amongst all the millions of stars we see, and billions of galaxies as well. There are so many, in fact, and spread across such distances, that even time itself is meaningless when looking up at space.

Imagine that only one in every 200 galaxies produced an intelligent species. That's only one star out of billions, across billions of years of time, gives rise to only one species at least as intelligent as us, then there could have been a billion intelligent species like us. A billion species who have lived and died out in the 14 billion history of our universe, and yet all separated by vast amounts of space and time, making it impossible for any species to ever find out that another existed. Just little isolated silos of life, sparking into existence and then being snuffed out again.

The metaverse might be no different.

Every large corporation wants to run their services like an isolated galaxy. This means that startups have

Expect to drown in metaverse offerings, and heck, we will probably be helping push your head under! We're going to be letting you know of the promising metaverse offerings as time passes, and there's bound to be plenty of them.

Those of us using whatever the work version of the metaverse becomes will have it easier. Our bosses will pick the metaverse to use from amongst the many in the multi-metaverse (or is that meta-multiverse?) and we will just go with the flow.

So did we answer the question about what the metaverse is? Probably not, because there is no one answer to that question. If you haven't already, you should really get started trying out some cheaper VR options, just to get used to it.

Expect a whole lot more than this cover story in terms of coverage too. As always, we'd love to hear your thoughts about the metaverse, and whether you're looking forward to it or terrified by it. [d](#)